

The Travelling Cool

As India and South Africa open a most-awaited contest, the practical visitors bring mystery with them—of just how they do so well where others sweat

| By Sharda Ugra |

So who's world cricket's No.1? The team that can beat Australia in Australia and then keel over at home a couple of months later? Or the one that can always annoy Australia and won't fold at home either? The one with better fast bowlers, despite injury breakdowns? Or the lot with the batsmen who bat once bat big and leave the others to wipe the crumbling opposition off the floor?

Two Tests in the next fortnight will keep the riddles coming. India vs South Africa in Nagpur and Kolkata will only be a short opening rumble. The loudest passages will be heard when India visit the Rainbow Republic at the end of the year.

For South Africa to become Test cricket's No.1, the series will have to be won 2-0. The last time a home series in India ended 0-2 was another 10 years ago in another two-week sprint and the winning tourists were er... South Africa. What happened after that included the Delhi Police, phone tapping and a fellow called Hansie Cronje, but let's not go there.

What has stayed in mind since then, is an Indian alertness against the one team that has troubled them most consistently at home. In the last decade, South Africa have played 10 Tests in India; won four, lost four and drawn two. Australia have played 11 but won only three, lost five, drawn three. England have won a single Test in eight, played in the same time, and lost three.

South Africa travel to India without boasting, preaching or whingeing. They land without history, without baggage and even without an endorsement deal in sight. South Africa travel with their cricket. Never mind what else they do in other hemispheres and

against other opposition. Against India, they have always found a way to compete as if it were the last match to be played on the planet. Since their return to international cricket in 1992, the only frontline Test nation where they have won more overseas Tests than India is England (six).

The journalists who travel with the South African team call their team's confidence in India, where environment and numbers don't add up anyway, a 'mystery'. It is their "compulsive obsession" to repeat wins which travels with them. The Indians that have played them dissect their mysteries into tangible parts.

Former captain Anil Kumble says South Africa play their cricket differently than other visitors, "They play the waiting game, handle spin better than most others. They're cautious, they don't try and attack, and they bat deep." The men who run in tend have also tended to be better than the pack from most other nations. Former Test opener Wasim

Jaffer has faced them twice in the last decade and says, "They don't ever complain about wickets or conditions. They just play. The bowlers just come hard."

India's ostensibly flat, batting-friendly tracks do not matter to men like Allan Donald who picked up 17 wickets @ 16.11 here (Ntini had 18 @ 27.11 and on his last tour, Dale Steyn had 15 from three Tests). Donald once said India taught you how to use the ball in the air rather than off the ground.

South Africa has learnt not to be daunted by India and India has learnt that South Africa do not choke here. The series will sizzle. Maybe we will even dissect the mystery. After all, India coach Gary Kirsten belonged to the team that set up South Africa's earliest inroads. Maybe he can unravel the secrets and undo it all—at least this once. ■

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